THE INVESTING GUIDE

STARTER

THINK RICHER™ STARTER PLAN

YOUR FIRST INVESTING PLAN. DONE RIGHT. DONE TODAY.

A step-by-step beginner guide to setting up your retirement investments — written in plain English. Build a diversified portfolio you actually understand, in about an hour.

WRITTEN BY

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START HERE

BUILD A PORTFOLIO YOU UNDERSTAND.

“What do I actually buy? How do I avoid doubling up on the same stuff? Which ETFs should I even pick?” You’re in the right place. This guide walks you through building a retirement investing plan in plain English.

BY THE END YOU’LL HAVE

1. Your starting mix of stocks and bonds, based on your age
2. A risk score that tilts the mix toward what you can actually stomach
3. A specific example portfolio you can copy or build around
4. BONUS at the end: a promo code for 1 month free of ETF Insight Pro

THREE THINGS BEFORE YOU START

Investing isn’t one-size-fits-all.
Work through the steps. You’ll end up with something you can stick with through the ups and downs.

Already investing?
Use this guide to spot gaps or tilt your mix toward what you like (more dividends, more growth, etc.).

Come back at least once a year.
Or any time life changes — new job, baby, marriage, getting closer to retiring. This becomes even more important as you get older: your mix should shift toward more bonds and less risk as you near (and enter) retirement.

USE THIS FOR RETIREMENT INVESTING.
Not for shorter goals like a car or house — those need different accounts and a different mix.

FIRST DECISION

HOW MUCH IN STOCKS VS. BONDS?

Your starting mix is based on your age today. Younger = more stocks (more growth, more bumps). Closer to retirement = more bonds (smaller bumps, more steady).

WHY AGE AND NOT A RETIREMENT DATE?
Because retirement doesn't end your investing. Most people stay invested for 20–30 years AFTER they retire.

AGE 20–37
95% Stocks / **5%** Bonds

AGE 38–42
92% Stocks / **8%** Bonds

AGE 43–47
90% Stocks / **10%** Bonds

AGE 48–52
82% Stocks / **18%** Bonds

AGE 53–57
67% Stocks / **33%** Bonds

AGE 58–62
58% Stocks / **42%** Bonds

AGE 63–64
51% Stocks / **49%** Bonds

DO THIS NOW: Find your age. Write down your stock % on a sticky note. You'll use it in Step 3.

SCORE YOURSELF

HOW MUCH RISK CAN YOU HANDLE?

SCORING RULES Pick ONE answer per question. A = 1 B = 2 C = 3 D = 4. Add them all up.

1. HOW BIG OF A TEMPORARY DROP COULD YOU HANDLE WITHOUT CHANGING YOUR PLAN?

- **A** A 5% drop → $1,000 becomes $950
- **B** A 10% drop → $1,000 becomes $900
- **C** A 20% drop → $1,000 becomes $800
- **D** A 30%+ drop → $1,000 becomes $700 or less

2. YOUR ACCOUNT DROPS 20% IN 6 MONTHS ($1,000 → $800). WHAT DO YOU ACTUALLY DO?

- **A** Sell to stop the bleeding
- **B** Pause — don't add new money for a while
- **C** Keep adding the same amount each month
- **D** Add EXTRA money while prices are cheaper

3. IF YOU LOST YOUR INCOME TODAY, HOW MANY MONTHS OF BASIC BILLS COULD YOUR SAVINGS COVER?

- **A** Less than 2 months
- **B** 2 to 5 months
- **C** 6 to 12 months
- **D** More than 12 months

THREE MORE QUESTIONS

KEEP SCORING. ADD IT ALL UP.

4. YOUR DEBT TODAY (DON'T COUNT YOUR PRIMARY-HOME MORTGAGE)

- A I have high-interest debt OR payments feel tight
- B I have some balances, but payments are manageable
- C I have low balances and payments feel comfortable
- D I have no debt or very small payments

5. HOW STEADY IS YOUR INCOME?

- A Very unsteady — pay or hours change a lot
- B Somewhat unsteady
- C Mostly steady
- D Very steady, or I have more than one reliable source

6. WHAT FEELS BETTER TO YOU WHEN YOU INVEST?

- A Smaller ups and downs and slower growth
- B Medium ups and downs and medium growth
- C Bigger ups and downs and higher growth
- D Very big ups and downs and the highest chance of growth

YOUR TOTAL

Add up all six points. Your total will be between 6 and 24.

Save it — you'll use it in Step 3.

TOTAL: ______

COMBINE STEP 1 + STEP 2

ADJUST YOUR MIX FOR REAL LIFE.

Your age says one thing. Your stomach says another. This step combines them.

WHY THIS STEP MATTERS

Age tells you how much TIME you have. Risk tolerance tells you how much DROP you can stomach without panic-selling. A mix that ignores your real risk tolerance is the one you bail on at the worst moment — locking in losses.

STEP A

Write down your base mix.

From the Age table in Step 1. Example: “82% stocks / 18% bonds.”

STEP B

Look up your risk score in the chart below.

Whatever % the chart says, subtract that from your stocks. Example: score 12 → subtract 15%.

STEP C

Add the same % to bonds.

Stocks + bonds should still equal 100%. That’s your adjusted mix.

RISK-SCORE ADJUSTMENT CHART

Score 6–9	Subtract 20% from stocks
Score 10–13	Subtract 15% from stocks
Score 14–17	Subtract 10% from stocks
Score 18–21	Subtract 5% from stocks
Score 22–24	No change

WORKED EXAMPLE

Base mix: 60% stocks / 40% bonds. Risk score: 12.
Score chart says → subtract 15% from stocks.

ADJUSTED MIX: 45% stocks / 55% bonds.

MATCH YOUR MIX TO A PAGE

FIND YOUR LET'S BUILD PAGE.

Take the stock % from your adjusted mix and round to the nearest page (the next 11 pages cover 0% all the way to 100% stocks in 10% steps).

ROUNDING EXAMPLES

72% stocks → use the 70% page.
78% stocks → use the 80% page.
Exactly in the middle (like 75%)? Lower STOCK % page = more stability. Higher STOCK % page = more growth.

COLOR KEY

These colors show up in every Let's Build pie chart.

U.S. STOCKS
Big and mid/small American companies (VOO + VXF).

INTERNATIONAL STOCKS
Non-U.S. companies — Europe, Asia, emerging markets (VXUS).

BONDS
Loans to the U.S. government and big companies (AGG + BSV).

CASH / MONEY MARKET
Safe parking spot for cash. Pays a little interest.

EXAMPLES, NOT RECOMMENDATIONS.
You can swap similar ETFs or build around what you already own. Always check tickers and fund names before buying.

EXAMPLE PORTFOLIO

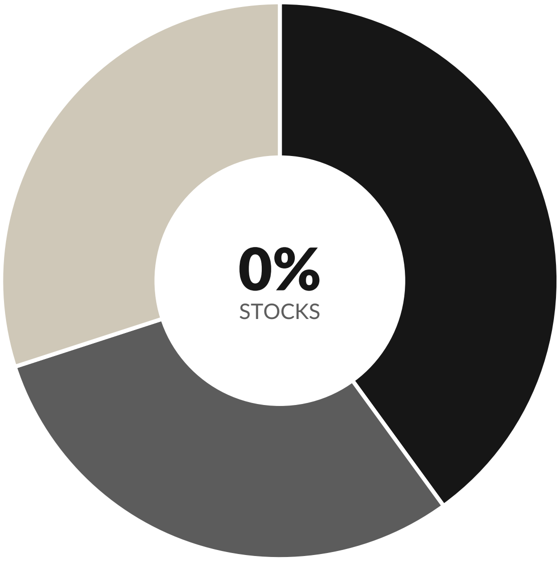
0% STOCKS

ULTRA CONSERVATIVE

When you need stability above all else.

HOW THIS WORKS

This is a $10,000 example. To use any other amount, multiply your dollar amount by each %. The percentages always add to 100%. ETFs are funds that hold many stocks or bonds at once — instant diversification.



YOUR HOLDINGS (based on a $10,000 example)

TICKER	FUND	ROLE	%	$10K EX.
AGG	U.S. Aggregate Bond (iShares)	U.S. Core Bonds	**40%**	**$4,000**
BSV	Short-Term Bond (Vanguard)	Short-Term U.S. Bonds	**30%**	**$3,000**
CASH	Money Market (SPAXX/VMFXX/SWVXX)	Cash / Money Market	**30%**	**$3,000**

TIP Already own similar funds? Keep them. The goal is to match the ROLES (U.S., International, Bonds, Cash) — not these exact tickers.

Example, not advice. Always check ticker and fund name before buying.

EXAMPLE PORTFOLIO

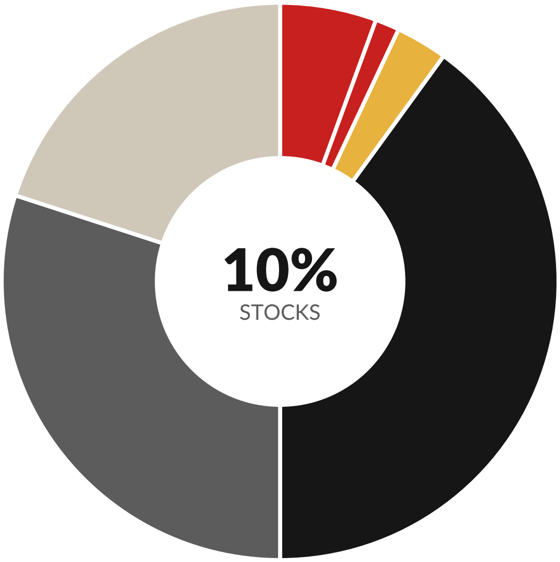
10% STOCKS

ULTRA CONSERVATIVE

A small sliver of growth on top of mostly bonds and cash.

HOW THIS WORKS

This is a $10,000 example. To use any other amount, multiply your dollar amount by each %. The percentages always add to 100%. ETFs are funds that hold many stocks or bonds at once — instant diversification.



YOUR HOLDINGS (based on a $10,000 example)

TICKER	FUND	ROLE	%	$10K EX.
VOO	S&P 500 (Vanguard)	U.S. Large Cap Stocks	5.6%	$560
VXF	Extended Market (Vanguard)	U.S. Mid / Small Cap Stocks	1.4%	$140
VXUS	Total International (Vanguard)	International Stocks	3%	$300
AGG	U.S. Aggregate Bond (iShares)	U.S. Core Bonds	40%	$4,000
BSV	Short-Term Bond (Vanguard)	Short-Term U.S. Bonds	30%	$3,000
CASH	Money Market	Cash / Money Market	20%	$2,000

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Example, not advice. Always check ticker and fund name before buying.

EXAMPLE PORTFOLIO

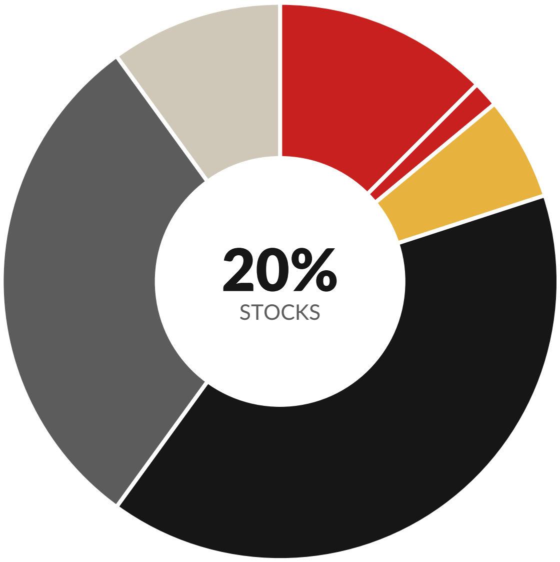
20% STOCKS

CONSERVATIVE

Stable, with a little equity for inflation protection.

HOW THIS WORKS

This is a $10,000 example. To use any other amount, multiply your dollar amount by each %. The percentages always add to 100%. ETFs are funds that hold many stocks or bonds at once — instant diversification.



YOUR HOLDINGS (based on a $10,000 example)

TICKER	FUND	ROLE	%	$10K EX.
VOO	S&P 500 (Vanguard)	U.S. Large Cap Stocks	**12.5%**	**$1,250**
VXF	Extended Market (Vanguard)	U.S. Mid / Small Cap Stocks	**1.5%**	**$150**
VXUS	Total International (Vanguard)	International Stocks	**6%**	**$600**
AGG	U.S. Aggregate Bond (iShares)	U.S. Core Bonds	**40%**	**$4,000**
BSV	Short-Term Bond (Vanguard)	Short-Term U.S. Bonds	**30%**	**$3,000**
CASH	Money Market	Cash / Money Market	**10%**	**$1,000**

TIP Already own similar funds? Keep them. The goal is to match the ROLES (U.S., International, Bonds, Cash) — not these exact tickers.

Example, not advice. Always check ticker and fund name before buying.

EXAMPLE PORTFOLIO

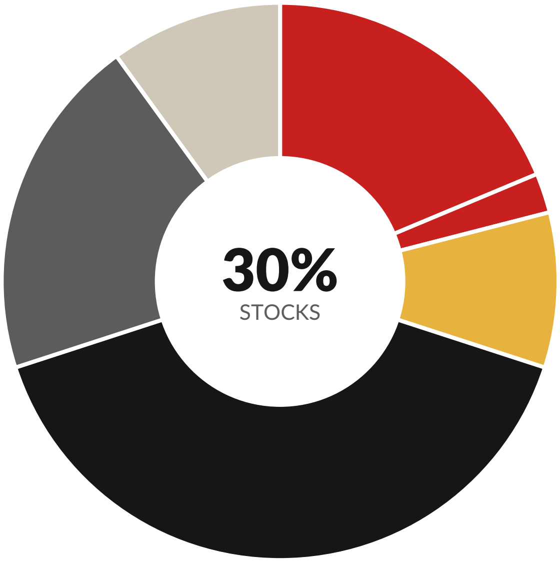
30% STOCKS

CONSERVATIVE INCOME

Income-leaning with modest growth.

HOW THIS WORKS

This is a $10,000 example. To use any other amount, multiply your dollar amount by each %. The percentages always add to 100%. ETFs are funds that hold many stocks or bonds at once — instant diversification.



YOUR HOLDINGS (based on a $10,000 example)

TICKER	FUND	ROLE	%	$10K EX.
VOO	S&P 500 (Vanguard)	U.S. Large Cap Stocks	**18.7%**	**$1,870**
VXF	Extended Market (Vanguard)	U.S. Mid / Small Cap Stocks	**2.3%**	**$230**
VXUS	Total International (Vanguard)	International Stocks	**9%**	**$900**
AGG	U.S. Aggregate Bond (iShares)	U.S. Core Bonds	**40%**	**$4,000**
BSV	Short-Term Bond (Vanguard)	Short-Term U.S. Bonds	**20%**	**$2,000**
CASH	Money Market	Cash / Money Market	**10%**	**$1,000**

TIP Already own similar funds? Keep them. The goal is to match the ROLES (U.S., International, Bonds, Cash) — not these exact tickers.

Example, not advice. Always check ticker and fund name before buying.

EXAMPLE PORTFOLIO

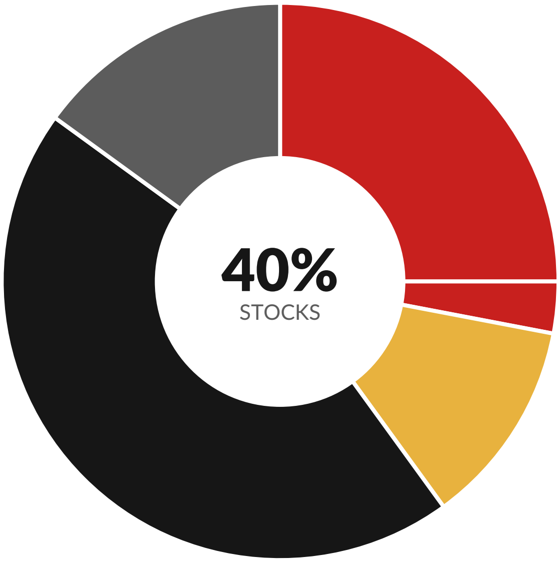
40% STOCKS

MODERATE

Roughly balanced between safety and growth.

HOW THIS WORKS

This is a $10,000 example. To use any other amount, multiply your dollar amount by each %. The percentages always add to 100%. ETFs are funds that hold many stocks or bonds at once — instant diversification.



YOUR HOLDINGS (based on a $10,000 example)

TICKER	FUND	ROLE	%	$10K EX.
VOO	S&P 500 (Vanguard)	U.S. Large Cap Stocks	**25%**	**$2,500**
VXF	Extended Market (Vanguard)	U.S. Mid / Small Cap Stocks	**3%**	**$300**
VXUS	Total International (Vanguard)	International Stocks	**12%**	**$1,200**
AGG	U.S. Aggregate Bond (iShares)	U.S. Core Bonds	**45%**	**$4,500**
BSV	Short-Term Bond (Vanguard)	Short-Term U.S. Bonds	**15%**	**$1,500**

TIP Already own similar funds? Keep them. The goal is to match the ROLES (U.S., International, Bonds, Cash) — not these exact tickers.

Example, not advice. Always check ticker and fund name before buying.

EXAMPLE PORTFOLIO

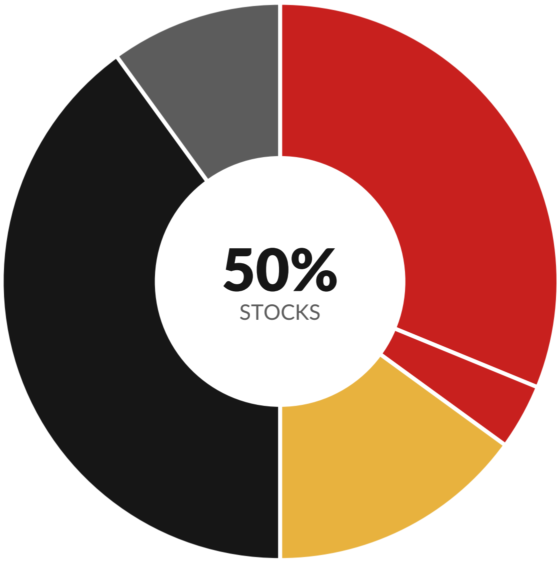
50% STOCKS

BALANCED

The classic half-and-half mix.

HOW THIS WORKS

This is a $10,000 example. To use any other amount, multiply your dollar amount by each %. The percentages always add to 100%. ETFs are funds that hold many stocks or bonds at once — instant diversification.



YOUR HOLDINGS (based on a $10,000 example)

TICKER	FUND	ROLE	%	$10K EX.
VOO	S&P 500 (Vanguard)	U.S. Large Cap Stocks	**31.2%**	**$3,120**
VXF	Extended Market (Vanguard)	U.S. Mid / Small Cap Stocks	**3.8%**	**$380**
VXUS	Total International (Vanguard)	International Stocks	**15%**	**$1,500**
AGG	U.S. Aggregate Bond (iShares)	U.S. Core Bonds	**40%**	**$4,000**
BSV	Short-Term Bond (Vanguard)	Short-Term U.S. Bonds	**10%**	**$1,000**

TIP Already own similar funds? Keep them. The goal is to match the ROLES (U.S., International, Bonds, Cash) — not these exact tickers.

Example, not advice. Always check ticker and fund name before buying.

EXAMPLE PORTFOLIO

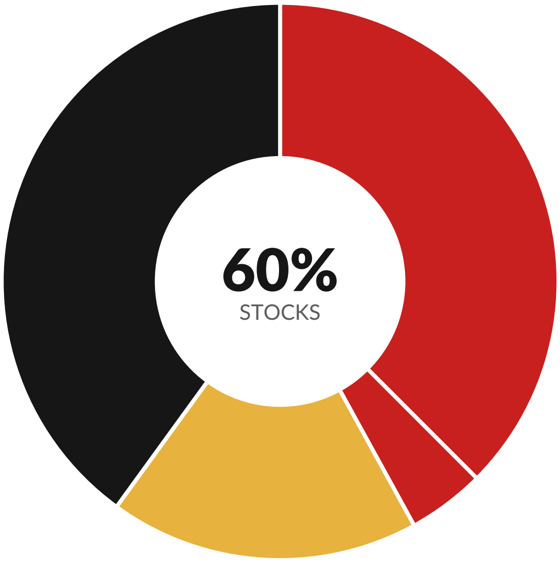
60% STOCKS

GROWTH WITH INCOME

Tilted toward growth, still meaningful bond cushion.

HOW THIS WORKS

This is a $10,000 example. To use any other amount, multiply your dollar amount by each %. The percentages always add to 100%. ETFs are funds that hold many stocks or bonds at once — instant diversification.



YOUR HOLDINGS (based on a $10,000 example)

TICKER	FUND	ROLE	%	$10K EX.
VOO	S&P 500 (Vanguard)	U.S. Large Cap Stocks	**37.5%**	**$3,750**
VXF	Extended Market (Vanguard)	U.S. Mid / Small Cap Stocks	**4.5%**	**$450**
VXUS	Total International (Vanguard)	International Stocks	**18%**	**$1,800**
AGG	U.S. Aggregate Bond (iShares)	U.S. Core Bonds	**40%**	**$4,000**

TIP Already own similar funds? Keep them. The goal is to match the ROLES (U.S., International, Bonds, Cash) — not these exact tickers.

Example, not advice. Always check ticker and fund name before buying.

EXAMPLE PORTFOLIO

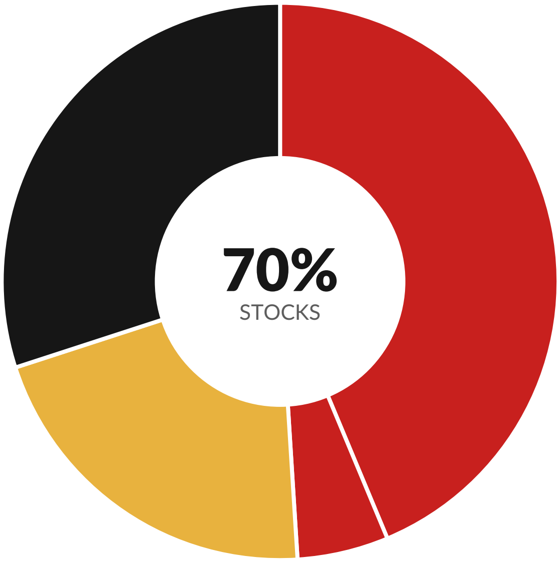
70% STOCKS

GROWTH

Growth-focused with a bond shock absorber.

HOW THIS WORKS

This is a $10,000 example. To use any other amount, multiply your dollar amount by each %. The percentages always add to 100%. ETFs are funds that hold many stocks or bonds at once — instant diversification.



YOUR HOLDINGS (based on a $10,000 example)

TICKER	FUND	ROLE	%	$10K EX.
VOO	S&P 500 (Vanguard)	U.S. Large Cap Stocks	43.7%	$4,370
VXF	Extended Market (Vanguard)	U.S. Mid / Small Cap Stocks	5.3%	$530
VXUS	Total International (Vanguard)	International Stocks	21%	$2,100
AGG	U.S. Aggregate Bond (iShares)	U.S. Core Bonds	30%	$3,000

TIP Already own similar funds? Keep them. The goal is to match the ROLES (U.S., International, Bonds, Cash) — not these exact tickers.

Example, not advice. Always check ticker and fund name before buying.

EXAMPLE PORTFOLIO

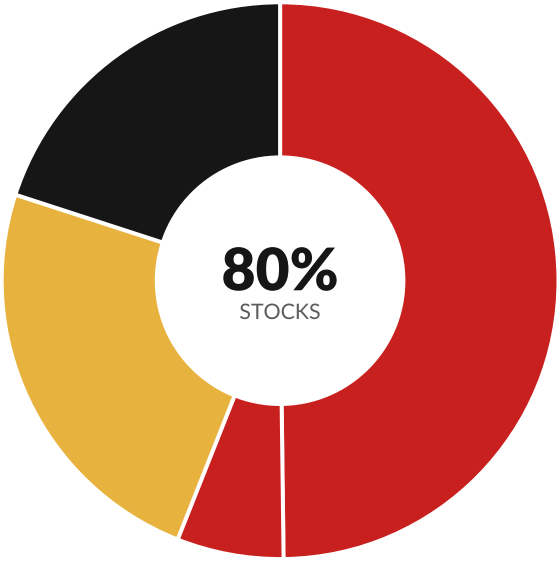
80% STOCKS

AGGRESSIVE GROWTH

Mostly stocks. Expect bigger ups AND downs.

HOW THIS WORKS

This is a $10,000 example. To use any other amount, multiply your dollar amount by each %. The percentages always add to 100%. ETFs are funds that hold many stocks or bonds at once — instant diversification.



YOUR HOLDINGS (based on a $10,000 example)

TICKER	FUND	ROLE	%	$10K EX.
VOO	S&P 500 (Vanguard)	U.S. Large Cap Stocks	**49.8%**	**$4,980**
VXF	Extended Market (Vanguard)	U.S. Mid / Small Cap Stocks	**6.2%**	**$620**
VXUS	Total International (Vanguard)	International Stocks	**24%**	**$2,400**
AGG	U.S. Aggregate Bond (iShares)	U.S. Core Bonds	**20%**	**$2,000**

TIP Already own similar funds? Keep them. The goal is to match the ROLES (U.S., International, Bonds, Cash) — not these exact tickers.

Example, not advice. Always check ticker and fund name before buying.

EXAMPLE PORTFOLIO

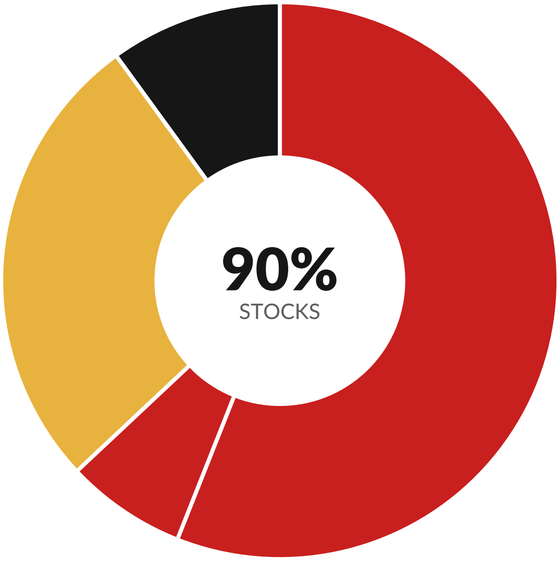
90% STOCKS

AGGRESSIVE GROWTH

Almost all stocks. Bonds are a thin cushion.

HOW THIS WORKS

This is a $10,000 example. To use any other amount, multiply your dollar amount by each %. The percentages always add to 100%. ETFs are funds that hold many stocks or bonds at once — instant diversification.



YOUR HOLDINGS (based on a $10,000 example)

TICKER	FUND	ROLE	%	$10K EX.
VOO	S&P 500 (Vanguard)	U.S. Large Cap Stocks	**56%**	**$5,600**
VXF	Extended Market (Vanguard)	U.S. Mid / Small Cap Stocks	**7%**	**$700**
VXUS	Total International (Vanguard)	International Stocks	**27%**	**$2,700**
AGG	U.S. Aggregate Bond (iShares)	U.S. Core Bonds	**10%**	**$1,000**

TIP Already own similar funds? Keep them. The goal is to match the ROLES (U.S., International, Bonds, Cash) — not these exact tickers.

Example, not advice. Always check ticker and fund name before buying.

EXAMPLE PORTFOLIO

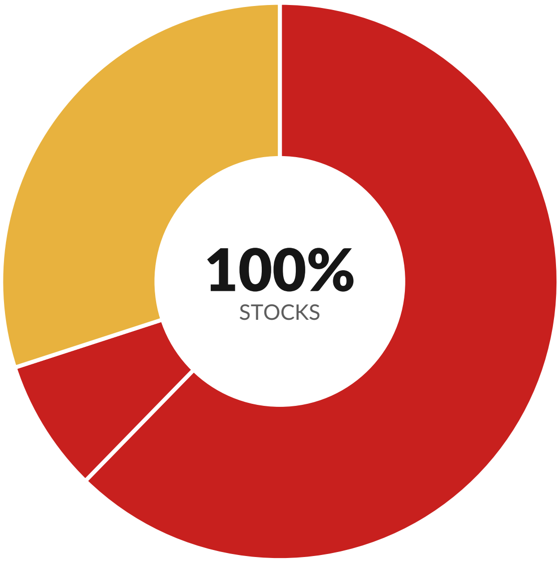
100% STOCKS

VERY AGGRESSIVE GROWTH

All stocks. Built for the longest time horizons.

HOW THIS WORKS

This is a $10,000 example. To use any other amount, multiply your dollar amount by each %. The percentages always add to 100%. ETFs are funds that hold many stocks or bonds at once — instant diversification.



YOUR HOLDINGS (based on a $10,000 example)

TICKER	FUND	ROLE	%	$10K EX.
VOO	S&P 500 (Vanguard)	U.S. Large Cap Stocks	**62.3%**	**$6,230**
VXF	Extended Market (Vanguard)	U.S. Mid / Small Cap Stocks	**7.7%**	**$770**
VXUS	Total International (Vanguard)	International Stocks	**30%**	**$3,000**

TIP Already own similar funds? Keep them. The goal is to match the ROLES (U.S., International, Bonds, Cash) — not these exact tickers.

Example, not advice. Always check ticker and fund name before buying.

THE FUNDS USED IN THIS GUIDE

WHAT IS AN ETF?

An ETF is a basket. One ETF can hold hundreds — even thousands — of stocks or bonds at once. So when you buy one share, you're buying a tiny slice of all of them. Less work for you. Lower risk than picking one stock.

VOO

S&P 500
VANGUARD • FEE 0.03%
The 500 biggest U.S. companies. Apple, Microsoft, Amazon... if it's a household name, it's probably in here.

VXF

EXTENDED MARKET
VANGUARD • FEE 0.06%
The REST of the U.S. market — mid-size and small companies that aren't in the S&P 500.

VXUS

TOTAL INTERNATIONAL STOCK
VANGUARD • FEE 0.05%
Stocks outside the U.S. — Europe, Asia, plus emerging markets like India and Brazil. ~8,500 holdings.

AGG

U.S. AGGREGATE BOND
ISHARES • FEE 0.03%
A wide mix of U.S. bonds — Treasuries plus high-quality corporate bonds. The bond cushion.

BSV

SHORT-TERM BOND INDEX
VANGUARD • FEE 0.04%
Shorter-term bonds. Less sensitive to interest rate changes. Steadier than AGG.

CASH → USE YOUR BROKER'S MONEY MARKET FUND
Fidelity: SPAXX • Vanguard: VMFXX • Schwab: SWVXX

FROM ZERO TO INVESTED

HOW TO ACTUALLY BUY THEM.

1. **PICK YOUR ACCOUNT**
   Open a brokerage at Fidelity, Vanguard, Schwab — whoever you like. For retirement, choose a Traditional or Roth IRA. (Your 401(k) is set up through your employer and has fewer fund choices.)
2. **FUND THE ACCOUNT**
   Link your bank. Move cash in. This can take a few business days the first time.
3. **FIND THE ETF**
   Type the ticker (the short code, like VOO). Double-check the full fund name — tickers can look alike.
4. **CHOOSE HOW MUCH**
   If your app supports fractional shares, type a dollar amount (e.g. $200). “Fractional” = part of a share. If not, type the number of whole shares.
5. **PICK YOUR ORDER TYPE**
   Market order = buy right now at the current price. Limit order = set the MAX price you’ll pay. Use a limit if you have a strict budget and can only buy whole shares.
6. **PLACE THE ORDER**
   Tap Buy. Review. Confirm. You’ll see a “fill price” once it goes through.
7. **REPEAT FOR EACH FUND**
   Buy each ETF in your mix. Done. You officially own a diversified portfolio.

ALL AT ONCE OR A LITTLE EACH MONTH?

Lump Sum vs. Dollar-Cost Averaging — here’s the difference.

LUMP SUM

PUT IT ALL IN AT ONCE

Historically beats DCA about 2 out of 3 times because markets generally go up. Best when you have the money now and can handle a short-term drop.

DOLLAR-COST AVERAGING

SAME AMOUNT, EVERY MONTH

Smooths out the bumps — you buy more shares when prices drop, fewer when they rise. Best when you’re nervous, or money trickles in via paychecks.

WINNING MOVE FOR MOST PEOPLE

Set up recurring auto-investments. You auto-DCA your paychecks AND remove the temptation to time the market.

PRO TIPS

- Set up recurring investments so your contributions happen on autopilot — no decisions, no temptation to time the market.
- Buy during normal market hours (9:30am – 4:00pm ET). Avoid the first and last few minutes of the day.
- Prices move during the day. That’s normal.

TRUE DIVERSIFICATION 101

GAPS & OVERLAP.

Diversification isn't just owning a lot of funds — it's owning DIFFERENT exposures. Two things to watch for when you check what you already own.

OVERLAP

Doubling up

Owning the same stuff twice.

Example: VOO + VTI. VTI already contains the S&P 500, so you're basically buying Apple and Microsoft twice. The bigger problem: when funds hold the same stocks, they move together. Up days, down days, crashes — your "diversified" portfolio is really one bet wearing two costumes. True diversification means owning DIFFERENT exposures, because no one knows which slice of the market wins next.

VOO | VTI

~85% identical stocks → moves together

GAP

What's missing

A whole category you're skipping.

Example: 100% U.S. stocks, zero international. International is roughly 40% of the global stock market — a huge chunk you're leaving out. It also moves differently than the U.S., so missing it means you ride every U.S. dip without a counterweight. Gaps often hide in 401(k) defaults and old IRAs that were never rebalanced.

U.S. | INTL?

Whole non-U.S. slice missing

MORE CONTROL, MORE RISK

TILT IT YOUR WAY.

Want extra control? You can lean your portfolio toward growth or value, lean bigger or smaller companies, focus international on developed OR emerging markets, or pick corporate vs. government bonds.

U.S. STOCK STYLE

VUG
Large Growth *Vanguard*

VTV
Large Value *Vanguard*

IJH
Mid Cap *iShares*

IJR
Small Cap *iShares*

FLAVOR & INCOME

VYM
High Dividend *Vanguard*

QQQM
NASDAQ-100 (Tech-heavy) *Invesco*

INTERNATIONAL

IDEV
Developed Markets *iShares*

IEMG
Emerging Markets *iShares*

BOND TYPE

USIG
Corporate Bonds *iShares*

GOVT
U.S. Treasury *iShares*

EXAMPLE TILT (100% STOCKS)

Swap VOO → VUG (large growth only). Swap VXUS → IDEV (developed only). Keep VXF.
Result: VUG 62.3% / VXF 7.7% / IDEV 30%.

Heads up: tilts reduce diversification — bigger ups AND bigger downs.

MALLORY WARREN, CFP®

THE FINE PRINT.

Educational, hypothetical content only. Last updated: May 13, 2026. Content may change without notice.

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